

88.1 The Battle of Agincourt

The next morning, the French offered to carry out further negotiations, but Henry V ordered his men to begin the charge. The first volley from the English archers, coordinated into a single devastating hail, brought down the entire French front line; the horses behind, many of them wounded, wheeled and charged back into the massed ranks. Others slipped in the mud—the field where they fought was newly planted with grain—and trapped their knights. The English foot soldiers drove forward with "swords, hatchets, mallets, and bill-hooks," slaughtering thousands. "Thus perished almost all the flower of French chivalry," Walsingham writes. Among the captives taken alive was the Duke of Orleans himself.[16]

Perhaps eight thousand French soldiers died; the total may have been higher. English chronicles insisted that Henry V lost only twenty-seven men, but Enguerrand de Monstrelet offers the more realistic sixteen hundred. Either way, it was a shattering defeat for the French, a soul-fulfilling victory for the English.[17]

Spectacular though it was, the triumph at Agincourt did not give Henry the French crown. His weakened and weary men were in no shape to continue campaigning, so rather than attempting to push on to Paris, Henry V took his prisoners and his men to Calais and set sail for home, where he was hailed in London as the "King of England and of France."

In the wake of Agincourt, the Count of Armagnac became Constable of